

ROHIT JAIN PARAS

**IN SOLIDARITY** BJP MP Kirodi Lal Meena with the victim's family in Jaipur

issued him a notice, then sent a vigilance team and deployed a guard. All along, a four-storey building—claimed to be a *dharamshala*—was coming up beside the temple. His family alleges it was a hotel, and that the temple management was eyeing their land to construct its parking lot. In his suicide statement, Ram Prasad claimed when his family approached Joshi, who was allegedly behind the orders to stop work on the house, the minister misbehaved with them. In his video, he also appealed to Kirodi Lal Meena, a BJP Rajya Sabha MP known for leading mass agitations, to ensure justice.

After the MP sat on a protest with the family, who refused to perform the last rites, the government assured a job, dairy booth and Rs 4 lakh relief to the kin. Police also arrested five people, including priests and hoteliers named by Ram Prasad, while Gehlot ordered the demolition of the four-storey building. But the CM is under pressure to act against Joshi, who has sought to wash his hands of the affair saying the temple management had indeed complained about Ram Prasad's "unauthorised construction", but that he had ordered no action. "There should be a thorough probe to bring out the truth and punish the guilty," he says.

**A TEA VENDOR'S SUICIDE AND A PAPER LEAK CASE SPELL TROUBLE FOR THE CONGRESS REGIME IN POLL-BOUND RAJASTHAN**

The case has put the spotlight on corruption in civic bodies, which have allowed unabated illegal constructions in the state. Official connivance is also the key enabling factor in Rajasthan's depressingly routine question paper leaks. Babulal Katara, appointed to the RPSC in 2020, was arrested by the special operations group on April 18, after "establishing his clear link" in a teacher selection exam paper leak. The Udaipur police exposed the racket when it caught 40 people trying to solve the paper in a moving bus just before the exam last December. Probe revealed that Katara had allegedly handed over the papers to his nephew, who jotted down the questions that were finally supplied to the candidates in lieu of money. Katara is suspected to have received at least Rs 60 lakh. The Opposition wants the Enforcement Directorate to investigate the extent of his ill-gotten assets.

Amid a spate of paper leaks, Gehlot has been seeking a nationwide coordinated effort. His government, in fact, amended the law to enhance the jail term for paper leak convicts to 10 years along with a Rs 10 crore fine. Unauthorised buildings owned by some of the accused have been razed too. But the arrest of a senior functionary has put Gehlot on the back foot. With polls round the corner, the CM will have to ensure a free and fair probe, and timely prosecution, to bring all the accused to book in both the cases. ■



**LUCK BY CHANCE** Don-turned-neta Anand Mohan Singh

caste dominance on the rural landscape. Mohan is expected to nudge that zone of influence towards the ruling Janata Dal (United)-Rashtriya Janata Dal alliance.

The alliance did not have a prominent Rajput leader with pan-Bihar following after the passing of RJD veteran Raghuvansh Prasad Singh. Mohan is expected to fill the void. Of the 40 Lok Sabha seats in Bihar, the Rajput community has considerable clout in at least eight—Marajganj, Aurangabad, East Champaran, Vaishali, Sheohar, Buxar, Ara and Banka.

Mohan's son Chetan Anand and wife Lovely Anand had contested on RJD tickets in the 2020 assembly poll. Chetan is now the Sheohar MLA. Deputy CM and RJD chief Tejashwi Yadav has defended Mohan's release order, alleging the controversy was a media creation. "There is no controversy. He has served his time and is being released legally," Tejashwi told reporters.

Mohan's tryst with politics started in 1990 when he first became an Janata Dal MLA, before positioning himself as the Rajput challenger to the OBC hegemony of the Lalu Yadav era. A two-time MP (1996 and '98), he helped Lovely win a Lok Sabha bypoll in 1994. The wife and son did a homecoming of sorts by joining the RJD in 2020. Things started looking up for the don after August 2022 when Nitish Kumar stitched a new alliance and government with the RJD. In the past six months alone, Mohan has been out on parole thrice.

**Things started looking up for the don after Aug. 2022 when the new JD(U)-RJD govt took shape**

The Central IAS Association has expressed "deep dismay" at the Bihar government's decision. "Such dilution leads to impunity, erosion in morale of public servants, undermines public order and makes a mockery of administration of justice," reads the association's Twitter message. Uma Krishnaiah, wife of the late Dalit bureaucrat berated the decision, and said she would take the advice of his IAS batchmates to decide her course of action. The last may not have been heard on this. ■